

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Finance English



Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For accounting, FP&A, treasury, banking, investments, audit, risk, corporate finance, and finance-adjacent teams.

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Finance Communication: Drivers, Assumptions, Materiality, Risk

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

02 Financial Statements, Close, and Accounting Judgments

Clarify missing information before responding.

03 FP&A, Budgeting, Forecasting, and Variance Analysis

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

04 Treasury, Cash, Liquidity, Working Capital, and FX

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

05 Markets, Investments, Performance, and Client Communication

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

06 Banking, Credit, Lending, and Counterparty Risk

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

07 Controls, Audit, Compliance, Fraud, and Ethics

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

08 Valuation, M&A, Capital Allocation, and Executive Finance

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Finance Communication: Drivers, Assumptions, Materiality, Risk

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

Revenue is 5% above budget, while operating profit is 2% below budget. A manager wants a one-sentence explanation for a review meeting.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Revenue - Income from delivering goods or services, recognized under applicable accounting rules.

Operating income - Profit from operations before items such as interest and taxes, depending on presentation.

Variance - Difference between actual and comparison point such as budget, forecast, or prior period.

Sensitivity - Analysis showing how results change when an assumption changes.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Improve this sentence: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 01 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
 - B. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
 - C. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?
 - B. How would you describe the next step in your own words?
 - C. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Revenue ahead, operating profit behind

The lesson's review shows revenue 5% above budget and operating profit 2% below. The causes are not supplied.

01 • Finance manager: Revenue is five percent above budget, while operating profit is two percent below budget.

02 • Operations director: That sounds contradictory. Doesn't higher revenue mean the business made more operating profit?

03 • Finance manager: Revenue measures sales; operating income also reflects operating costs. The two variances can differ.

04 • Operations director: Can we say higher staff costs caused the profit shortfall in this case?

05 • Finance manager: Not from the figures provided. We haven't established the cost or mix drivers.

06 • Operations director: Then give me a one-sentence explanation that preserves what we actually know.

07 • Finance manager: Sales exceeded budget, but operating profit fell short; the reasons for that difference still need review.

08 • Operations director: That distinguishes the result from the explanation without hiding the unfavorable variance.

09 • Finance manager: Exactly. A sensitivity analysis could explore assumptions, but it wouldn't establish the actual cause.

10 • Operations director: I'll use that qualified summary and ask for the driver analysis separately.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Higher revenue per unit, unchanged unit sales

Separate fictional planning exercise: revenue rises from \$100,000 to \$110,000 while unit sales remain at 1,000; the revenue breakdown is available only at this level.

01 • Sales director: Revenue rose from one hundred thousand to one hundred ten thousand dollars. We sold more units, then?

02 • Finance analyst: Unit sales stayed at one thousand. Revenue growth and volume growth aren't the same here.

03 • Sales director: So the average revenue per unit moved from one hundred to one hundred ten dollars?

04 • Finance analyst: Yes, using these totals. That doesn't tell us whether pricing, discounts, or product mix changed.

05 • Sales director: I was about to credit a higher list price for the entire variance.

06 • Finance analyst: We need the detailed breakdown before making that attribution. The average alone doesn't isolate it.

07 • Sales director: Could you explain the distinction in the meeting using those two averages?

08 • Finance analyst: Certainly. The company earned more revenue per unit in aggregate, but the underlying drivers remain unconfirmed.

09 • Sales director: I'll separate the arithmetic from the pricing explanation in my remarks.

10 • Finance analyst: Good. We'll review the transaction detail before concluding which driver caused the movement.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Sensitivity is a what-if, not a forecast update

Separate fictional model review: an analyst tests a 10% fuel-cost increase without changing the approved forecast assumptions.

01 • Business manager: Your model shows fuel cost up ten percent. Has that become our new forecast?

02 • FP&A analyst: No. It's a sensitivity test showing what changes if that assumption is varied.

03 • Business manager: Then the operating-income result is conditional, not a prediction that fuel will rise that much?

04 • FP&A analyst: Correct. The approved forecast assumptions haven't been changed by this separate test.

05 • Business manager: Why show a case we don't claim will actually occur next period?

06 • FP&A analyst: It helps explain exposure: how dependent the result is on one uncertain input.

07 • Business manager: Could other costs change at the same time in a real situation?

08 • FP&A analyst: They could. This test isolates one input and doesn't describe every possible interaction.

09 • Business manager: I'll call it a fuel-cost sensitivity and keep it separate from the forecast.

10 • FP&A analyst: That preserves the distinction between exploring risk and updating our expected financial result.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Finance Communication: Drivers, Assumptions, Materiality, Risk

Revenue is 5% above budget, while operating profit is 2% below budget. A manager wants a one-sentence explanation for a review meeting.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: Revenue exceeded budget, but higher operating costs more than offset the increase. I'll show the main cost drivers so the review explains why profit moved differently from revenue.

Scenario 2 | A percentage-point correction

A fictional review reports an operating margin rising from 8% to 10%. A speaker calls that a two-percent relative increase. No causes have been investigated.

Role A: You are the finance analyst. Explain the two-percentage-point change and the different relative calculation.

Role B: You are the business manager. Paraphrase the distinction without assigning an unsupported cause.

Possible opening: The margin increased by two percentage points; that is different from a two-percent relative increase.

Success checks

- State the absolute movement as two percentage points.
- Explain that the relative increase from eight to ten is 25%.
- Keep the cause unresolved.

Add a complication: A stakeholder wants to credit automation even though no driver analysis is available.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Financial Statements, Close, and Accounting Judgments

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

An invoice covers services delivered in December but was paid in January. A colleague asks which month should appear in the close schedule.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Accrual - An accounting estimate recorded before cash payment or receipt occurs.

Deferred revenue - Cash received before revenue is recognized.

Working capital - Operational assets and liabilities such as receivables, inventory, and payables.

Reconciliation - Process of comparing records and resolving differences.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Improve this sentence: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 02 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when starts the review?
 - B. Could you confirm when the review starts?
 - C. Could you confirm when does the review start?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?
 - B. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?
 - C. Who will present the report at the meeting?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Which month does the close schedule mean?

The lesson's invoice covers services delivered in December and paid in January; accounting treatment requires contextual review.

01 • Accounts assistant: The services were delivered in December and paid in January. Which month goes in the close schedule?

02 • Financial controller: First, which column do you mean: service period, payment date, or proposed accounting period?

03 • Accounts assistant: The proposed accounting period. I assumed it should match the month cash left the bank.

04 • Financial controller: Cash timing and expense recognition are distinct. We need to check the applicable basis and supporting records.

05 • Accounts assistant: Should I ask whether an accrual was already recorded for the December services?

06 • Financial controller: Yes. That matters for reconciliation and helps avoid treating the same item twice.

07 • Accounts assistant: I'll preserve December as the service period and January as the payment period.

08 • Financial controller: Good. Don't finalize an accounting treatment solely from our short conversation.

09 • Accounts assistant: I'll bring the invoice and any accrual reference for review before changing the schedule.

10 • Financial controller: Then we can confirm the entry using the actual records and applicable accounting approach.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Cash received before the service begins

Separate fictional close exercise: a customer pays in advance for a future service; no revenue-recognition assessment has been completed.

01 • Billing analyst: The customer paid in advance. Can I label the whole receipt as this month's revenue?

02 • Controller: Could you clarify when the service is provided and what the schedule is intended to show?

03 • Billing analyst: The service is future work, and the schedule supports the financial close.

04 • Controller: Then receiving cash alone doesn't establish the revenue treatment. We need the relevant agreement and accounting assessment.

05 • Billing analyst: Is deferred revenue a label we should consider rather than assume automatically?

06 • Controller: Yes. Bring the facts for review instead of choosing a treatment from the payment date alone.

07 • Billing analyst: We haven't checked whether any part of the service has already been delivered.

08 • Controller: Keep that unknown visible. It may matter to the assessment and reconciliation.

09 • Billing analyst: I'll gather the agreement, receipt reference, and service-status information for the close reviewer.

10 • Controller: Good. We'll distinguish confirmed cash receipt from the accounting conclusion still under review.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A reconciliation difference needs a cutoff question

Separate fictional close exercise: a bank export ends Friday, while the internal cash schedule includes Monday entries.

01 • Reconciliation analyst: The bank export and internal schedule don't match. Could you confirm their cutoff dates?

02 • Treasury accountant: The bank export ends Friday, but the internal schedule includes Monday entries.

03 • Reconciliation analyst: Then we are comparing different periods. That may explain part of the difference.

04 • Treasury accountant: Can we mark the entire difference resolved just by noting that mismatch?

05 • Reconciliation analyst: No. We need to align the periods and check the entries before confirming reconciliation.

06 • Treasury accountant: Would you prefer a Friday internal view or a bank export through Monday?

07 • Reconciliation analyst: Either could support a consistent comparison, provided the close reviewer confirms the required cutoff.

08 • Treasury accountant: I'll ask that focused question rather than select whichever view makes the difference disappear.

09 • Reconciliation analyst: Please retain both original extracts so the change in scope remains traceable.

10 • Treasury accountant: Agreed. We'll reconcile the matching period and report anything still unmatched afterward.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Financial Statements, Close, and Accounting Judgments

An invoice covers services delivered in December but was paid in January. A colleague asks which month should appear in the close schedule.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: Are we discussing the cash payment date or the accounting period for the expense? The payment was in January; the accounting treatment needs to follow our policy and the service details.

Scenario 2 | A credit note without a linked invoice

A fictional close file contains a credit note but no linked invoice reference. Its cash settlement status and prior accounting entry are unknown.

Role A: You prepare the close schedule. Request the invoice linkage and existing-entry information before proposing treatment.

Role B: You are the billing coordinator. State what is missing and agree how to retrieve it.

Possible opening: Could you confirm which invoice this credit note relates to and whether an entry is already recorded?

Success checks

- Ask for the invoice link and prior entry.
- Preserve the unknown settlement status.
- Agree a records check rather than an unsupported accounting classification.

Add a complication: Someone suggests classifying it by the credit note's filename alone.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

FP&A, Budgeting, Forecasting, and Variance Analysis

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

SITUATION

The forecast shows \$120,000 of spending against a \$100,000 budget. A new supplier fee accounts for \$15,000; the remaining \$5,000 is under review.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Budget - Approved financial plan for a period.

Forecast - Updated estimate of future performance based on current information.

Variance - Difference between actual and comparison point such as budget, forecast, or prior period.

Bridge - Step-by-step explanation from one financial number to another.

3. Notice the language

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Improve this sentence: Everything is progressing well.

LESSON 03 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Give a useful status update

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence says a review is finished?
 - A. The team has completed the review.
 - B. The team is completing the review.
 - C. The team plans to complete the review.
2. Which update distinguishes a plan from a confirmed fact?
 - A. Delivery is confirmed for Friday because we planned it.
 - B. The delivery plan proves that arrival will be Friday.
 - C. Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A twenty-thousand-dollar bridge with a gap

The lesson's spending forecast is \$120,000 against a \$100,000 budget; \$15,000 relates to a supplier fee and \$5,000 remains under review.

01 • FP&A analyst: The forecast exceeds budget by twenty thousand dollars. Fifteen thousand relates to the new supplier fee.

02 • Department manager: Then can we say supplier costs explain the full unfavorable variance?

03 • FP&A analyst: No. The remaining five thousand is still under review and needs its own line in the bridge.

04 • Department manager: What part of the analysis is complete enough for today's discussion?

05 • FP&A analyst: The total comparison and identified supplier fee. The unexplained balance remains pending.

06 • Department manager: Does this mean we have already spent one hundred twenty thousand dollars?

07 • FP&A analyst: No. That is the forecast, not a supplied actual-spending figure.

08 • Department manager: I'll distinguish forecast from actuals and avoid filling the gap with a guessed cause.

09 • FP&A analyst: I'll update the bridge when the remaining five thousand has been investigated.

10 • Department manager: Good. Present the known driver and open balance together so the total still reconciles.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Forecast submitted but not approved

Separate fictional planning exercise: a department submitted a revised forecast; the finance review is still pending and the budget is unchanged.

01 • Department lead: We submitted the revised forecast. Can I announce that our spending budget has increased?

02 • Planning analyst: No. Submission isn't approval, and a forecast update doesn't itself change the authorized budget.

03 • Department lead: Then what progress can I report without understating the work already completed?

04 • Planning analyst: Say the revision was submitted and finance review remains pending; the budget is unchanged.

05 • Department lead: Could the forecast still help us discuss the expected variance while review continues?

06 • Planning analyst: Yes, provided it is labeled submitted rather than approved and compared with the current budget.

07 • Department lead: I'll make those statuses explicit instead of combining them into a single updated number.

08 • Planning analyst: Please also retain the original assumptions so reviewers can see what changed.

09 • Department lead: When the review finishes, we'll communicate its outcome separately from the submission milestone.

10 • Planning analyst: Exactly. That keeps progress visible without implying spending authority that hasn't been granted.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A timing shift is not a permanent saving

Separate fictional forecast review: \$12,000 of planned maintenance moved from March to April; the annual scope and total remain unchanged.

01 • Operations manager: March's forecast is twelve thousand dollars lower. Can we call that a maintenance saving?

02 • Finance analyst: The work moved to April, and the annual total hasn't changed. It's a timing shift.

03 • Operations manager: So March improves against its original plan, but the cost hasn't disappeared?

04 • Finance analyst: Correct. The bridge should show the movement between periods, not a reduction in annual scope.

05 • Operations manager: Is there anything still pending in the analysis before the monthly review?

06 • Finance analyst: We need to confirm that both months reflect the same twelve-thousand-dollar shift consistently.

07 • Operations manager: I'll avoid presenting March alone as proof of a lower full-year cost.

08 • Finance analyst: Good. The completed finding is the rescheduling; the cross-period check remains to be confirmed.

09 • Operations manager: Let's show March and April together so the timing effect is visible.

10 • Finance analyst: I'll bring that comparison and leave any actual saving claim out of the update.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | FP&A, Budgeting, Forecasting, and Variance Analysis

The forecast shows \$120,000 of spending against a \$100,000 budget. A new supplier fee accounts for \$15,000; the remaining \$5,000 is under review.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Second round: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Model for scenario 1: Spending is forecast to be \$20,000 above budget. The supplier fee explains \$15,000 of that variance. We are still reviewing the remaining \$5,000 and will update the bridge tomorrow.

Scenario 2 | An incomplete headcount forecast

A fictional forecast includes salary assumptions for six planned hires, but start dates for two are unconfirmed. The approved headcount budget has not changed.

Role A: You are the planning analyst. Report completed inputs and the two unresolved start-date assumptions.

Role B: You manage recruitment. Ask how the uncertainty affects the forecast without treating it as hiring approval.

Possible opening: Six roles are modeled, but two start dates are assumptions we still need to confirm.

Success checks

- Identify two unconfirmed dates out of six roles.
- Separate forecast assumptions from approved headcount.
- Agree who will check the dates and how uncertainty remains visible.

Add a complication: A sponsor asks you to present all six start dates as agreed to simplify the update.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Treasury, Cash, Liquidity, Working Capital, and FX

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

A cash forecast assumes a large customer pays on Friday. The customer has not confirmed payment. A manager asks if the cash balance is guaranteed.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Liquidity - Ability to meet obligations when due without unacceptable loss or disruption.

Cash runway - How long available cash is expected to last at current or projected burn.

Revolver - A revolving credit facility that can be drawn and repaid within agreed limits.

FX exposure - Potential financial impact from movements in foreign exchange rates.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Improve this sentence: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 04 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change must have caused the delay.
 - B. The change definitely caused the delay.
 - C. The change may have contributed to the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. Across the service, the observed result was ...
 - B. In this pilot, the observed result was ...
 - C. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Friday's receipt is still an assumption

The lesson's cash forecast assumes a large customer pays Friday; the customer has not confirmed payment.

01 • Operations director: The cash forecast looks sufficient. Is Friday's closing cash balance guaranteed?

02 • Treasury analyst: No. It assumes the large customer pays Friday, and that payment is unconfirmed.

03 • Operations director: Then what is the confirmed observation, as distinct from the planning assumption?

04 • Treasury analyst: The forecast includes the expected receipt. We don't yet have customer confirmation of the payment.

05 • Operations director: Could we describe liquidity as secure because the model shows enough cash?

06 • Treasury analyst: That would overstate the evidence. The modeled balance depends on the receipt arriving as assumed.

07 • Operations director: Would a delayed-receipt case help explain the exposure without predicting a delay?

08 • Treasury analyst: Yes. We can examine that scenario and clearly label it as conditional.

09 • Operations director: I'll request the payment-status check and avoid treating the base case as a guarantee.

10 • Treasury analyst: I'll present the assumption and alternative timing case together for the liquidity discussion.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

An undrawn facility is not unrestricted cash

Separate fictional treasury exercise: a report lists cash and an undrawn revolver separately; availability conditions have not been reviewed.

01 • Business manager: Could we add the undrawn revolver to cash and call the total immediately available?

02 • Treasury manager: Not without reviewing availability conditions. An undrawn facility isn't the same as cash already held.

03 • Business manager: The report lists a facility amount, but doesn't confirm what can actually be drawn today.

04 • Treasury manager: Exactly. That figure alone doesn't establish usable liquidity at this moment.

05 • Business manager: Should the cash-runway discussion exclude it entirely, then, as though it had no relevance?

06 • Treasury manager: We should show it separately with the conditions unresolved, rather than assume either availability or irrelevance.

07 • Business manager: I'll ask for the facility review before presenting a combined liquidity claim.

08 • Treasury manager: Please also retain the distinction between observed cash and potential funding sources.

09 • Business manager: Then leadership can see the open question rather than mistake the headline for a guarantee.

10 • Treasury manager: Good. We'll update the assessment when the relevant conditions have actually been checked.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A currency assumption is not a locked rate

Separate fictional forecast: a foreign-currency invoice is converted using a planning rate; no executed hedge or agreed settlement rate is supplied.

01 • Procurement manager: The forecast shows a fixed domestic-currency cost. Has treasury locked that exchange rate?

02 • Treasury analyst: No executed hedge is supplied here. The figure uses a planning exchange-rate assumption.

03 • Procurement manager: So the invoice amount and its translated forecast value are different kinds of information?

04 • Treasury analyst: Yes. The translated value depends on the assumed rate, and the FX exposure remains to be assessed.

05 • Procurement manager: Could we claim the actual settlement cost will match the forecast exactly?

06 • Treasury analyst: Not from these facts. We haven't established a locked rate or the settlement conditions.

07 • Procurement manager: I'll describe the domestic-currency figure as modeled, not guaranteed cash outflow.

08 • Treasury analyst: Good. We can show rate sensitivities without implying that any one rate will occur.

09 • Procurement manager: I'll ask who can confirm the exposure and any existing arrangements before the review.

10 • Treasury analyst: Then the discussion can separate known invoice terms from uncertain conversion outcomes.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Treasury, Cash, Liquidity, Working Capital, and FX

A cash forecast assumes a large customer pays on Friday. The customer has not confirmed payment. A manager asks if the cash balance is guaranteed.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: The forecast assumes payment on Friday; that date is not confirmed. I'll show the balance both with and without the receipt so the team can see the liquidity exposure.

Scenario 2 | Payment reported; receipt unconfirmed

A fictional customer says a payment instruction was submitted. The receiving bank record has not been checked, and the forecast currently includes the receipt today.

Role A: You are the treasury analyst. Distinguish the customer's statement from confirmed receipt.

Role B: You are the collections lead. Ask what confirmation is needed and how to describe today's cash forecast.

Possible opening: The customer reports submitting an instruction, but we haven't confirmed receipt in our bank record.

Success checks

- Attribute the customer's report accurately.
- Keep receipt and timing unconfirmed.
- Agree a bank-record check and a qualified forecast statement.

Add a complication: A manager wants the incoming amount counted as settled cash immediately.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Markets, Investments, Performance, and Client Communication

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

SITUATION

A portfolio return is 6% before fees. Its benchmark returned 5% over the same stated period. A slide does not identify fee treatment.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Return - Gain or loss on an investment over a period, usually expressed as a percentage.

Benchmark - Reference index or target used to evaluate performance.

Volatility - Degree of price movement or variability over time.

Attribution - Analysis explaining sources of portfolio return or relative performance.

3. Notice the language

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Improve this sentence: This option is more better.

LESSON 05 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Explain a fair comparison

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence expresses a clear contrast?
 - A. Option A is faster, so option B costs less.
 - B. Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.
 - C. Option A is faster because option B costs less.
2. A rate increases from 6% to 7%. What is the absolute difference?
 - A. An increase of one percentage point.
 - B. An increase of one percent relative to the original rate.
 - C. An increase of seven percentage points.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Six percent before fees needs a visible label

The lesson's portfolio return is 6% before fees and the benchmark returned 5% over the same period. Benchmark treatment needs clarification.

01 • Investment analyst: The portfolio returned six percent before fees; the benchmark returned five percent over the same period.

02 • Client reporting manager: Can the slide simply say investors outperformed by one percent?

03 • Investment analyst: We should say one percentage point on the stated figures, with fee treatment clearly identified.

04 • Client reporting manager: Because the portfolio figure doesn't establish the return each investor received after charges?

05 • Investment analyst: Correct. We also need to confirm the benchmark's calculation basis for a fair comparison.

06 • Client reporting manager: Should volatility or attribution be included if we want to discuss more than the headline return?

07 • Investment analyst: Yes, where supported. The return difference alone doesn't explain risk or the sources of performance.

08 • Client reporting manager: I'll retain the shared period and request a comparable fee basis before finalizing the claim.

09 • Investment analyst: Good. Avoid converting this historical comparison into a promise about future performance.

10 • Client reporting manager: The slide will state the measured result, its basis, and the remaining comparison limits.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Different periods cannot rank performance fairly

Separate fictional reporting exercise: fund A's summary covers twelve months, while fund B's covers six months. No matched-period figures are available.

01 • Reporting associate: Fund A's return is higher, but its summary covers twelve months and fund B's covers six.

02 • Performance specialist: Then those figures don't provide a like-for-like ranking over the same investment period.

03 • Reporting associate: Could I double the six-month result to estimate the missing twelve-month figure?

04 • Performance specialist: That would invent performance for a period we haven't measured. Request matched-period data instead.

05 • Reporting associate: Should the same benchmark and fee treatment also be checked before comparing them?

06 • Performance specialist: Yes. Different strategies may need explanation too; a single ranking can hide important differences.

07 • Reporting associate: For now, I'll display the two periods explicitly and withhold the better-performing label.

08 • Performance specialist: Good. We can discuss what the summaries show without pretending the comparison is complete.

09 • Reporting associate: I'll ask for the common-period returns and relevant volatility information.

10 • Performance specialist: Then we can describe the observed tradeoffs, not make an unsupported investment recommendation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A higher return with greater variation

Separate fictional training dataset: portfolios A and B have same-period, same-fee-basis returns of 7% and 6%; A's measured volatility is higher.

01 • Portfolio reporting lead: Portfolio A returned seven percent, versus six percent for B, on the same stated basis.

02 • Review analyst: A also had higher measured volatility. The comparison shouldn't imply the higher return came without a tradeoff.

03 • Portfolio reporting lead: Would volatility mean how much the returns varied, rather than simply whether money was lost?

04 • Review analyst: Yes. Explain the measure used; it doesn't capture every form of investment risk.

05 • Portfolio reporting lead: Then we can compare the observed return and variation without deciding which portfolio suits a client.

06 • Review analyst: Exactly. Suitability isn't established by these two historical measures alone.

07 • Portfolio reporting lead: I'll say A had a higher return and higher measured volatility in this dataset.

08 • Review analyst: Please keep the period and fee basis visible so the statement remains checkable.

09 • Portfolio reporting lead: And any attribution of that difference needs separate evidence about the underlying holdings.

10 • Review analyst: Agreed. The comparison is informative, but neither a complete risk assessment nor future guidance.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Markets, Investments, Performance, and Client Communication

A portfolio return is 6% before fees. Its benchmark returned 5% over the same stated period. A slide does not identify fee treatment.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Second round: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Model for scenario 1: The figures suggest a one-percentage-point difference before fees. We should label fee treatment and confirm the comparison basis before describing the performance to a client.

Scenario 2 | A return series with withdrawals

A fictional portfolio's ending balance is lower than its opening balance, and the account had a withdrawal. No calculated performance return is supplied.

Role A: You prepare performance reports. Explain why balance movement alone does not identify investment return.

Role B: You review client communication. Ask for a calculation that accounts for the cash flow and a comparable benchmark basis.

Possible opening: The balance declined, but the withdrawal means that movement is not itself the investment return.

Success checks

- Separate cash flow from investment performance.
- Do not invent an unsupplied return.
- Agree to obtain the appropriate calculation before benchmarking.

Add a complication: Someone wants to call the entire balance decline a market loss.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Banking, Credit, Lending, and Counterparty Risk

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

SITUATION

A credit file is missing an updated financial statement. The review team needs it for a scheduled meeting on Thursday.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Credit risk - Risk that a borrower or counterparty does not meet obligations.

Collateral - Assets pledged to support repayment or reduce loss severity.

DSCR - Debt service coverage ratio; cash flow relative to required debt payments.

Probability of default - Estimated likelihood that a borrower defaults.

3. Notice the language

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Improve this sentence: Please revert soonest with the necessary.

LESSON 06 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask for an actionable next step

4. Check the language

1. What does 'Please send it by Thursday' normally mean?
 - A. Send it no later than Thursday.
 - B. Send it on Thursday, but not earlier.
 - C. Keep sending it regularly until Thursday.
2. Which request gives the recipient enough detail to act?
 - A. Could you confirm that the review is important?
 - B. Could you confirm that you received my earlier message?
 - C. Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Requesting the statement for Thursday's review

The lesson's credit file lacks an updated financial statement needed for a Thursday review meeting.

01 • Credit analyst: Could you provide the updated financial statement for the credit review scheduled on Thursday?

02 • Relationship manager: Which gap does that document address, and are you promising approval if it arrives?

03 • Credit analyst: It fills a missing part of the file. Receipt would not itself establish a credit decision.

04 • Relationship manager: I can request it from the borrower, but I can't guarantee their delivery time.

05 • Credit analyst: Please ask when it can be supplied and let us know if Thursday's review may lack it.

06 • Relationship manager: Should I also request clarification of any figures needed for the DSCR analysis?

07 • Credit analyst: Yes, identify the actual missing inputs rather than estimate them from an outdated statement.

08 • Relationship manager: I'll keep the request focused on the review evidence, not suggest a favorable outcome.

09 • Credit analyst: Thank you. Credit risk and collateral assessment remain matters for the full review.

10 • Relationship manager: I'll confirm the borrower's response and distinguish promised delivery from a document actually received.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A collateral valuation with an unknown date

Separate fictional credit review: a collateral valuation is present, but its effective date is absent from the summary.

01 • Credit reviewer: Could you confirm the valuation's effective date before we rely on this collateral summary?

02 • Loan officer: The summary has a value but no date. I haven't checked the full report.

03 • Credit reviewer: Please retrieve the report and identify its scope as well as the date.

04 • Loan officer: Would finding those details mean the collateral is sufficient for the proposed facility?

05 • Credit reviewer: No. That conclusion needs the relevant review; this request addresses an evidence gap only.

06 • Loan officer: I'll ask for the report through the file process and confirm when it's available.

07 • Credit reviewer: If it can't be obtained before the review, flag the limitation rather than substitute an assumption.

08 • Loan officer: Understood. I'll avoid presenting the summary value as a current verified assessment.

09 • Credit reviewer: Good. We need the basis before discussing how collateral affects the credit-risk analysis.

10 • Loan officer: I'll return the source details or a clear statement of what remains missing.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Requesting the model definition behind default risk

Separate fictional credit exercise: a dashboard shows a probability-of-default estimate with no model version or horizon stated.

01 • Risk manager: Could you identify the horizon and model version behind this probability-of-default estimate?

02 • Credit data analyst: Those fields aren't in the dashboard extract. I'll need to check the model documentation.

03 • Risk manager: Please do that before the estimate is compared with the other portfolio's figure.

04 • Credit data analyst: Is the concern that a one-year estimate may not match a differently defined measure?

05 • Risk manager: Exactly. We need comparable definitions, not merely two percentages with the same label.

06 • Credit data analyst: Should I describe this estimate as a prediction that the borrower will default?

07 • Risk manager: No. It is a model estimate requiring context, not a certain individual outcome.

08 • Credit data analyst: I'll request the documentation and note that the comparison remains incomplete.

09 • Risk manager: Please confirm realistic delivery timing rather than promise it before checking access.

10 • Credit data analyst: I'll return the definitions and source references, or flag any remaining gap promptly.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Banking, Credit, Lending, and Counterparty Risk

A credit file is missing an updated financial statement. The review team needs it for a scheduled meeting on Thursday.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: Could you send the latest approved financial statements through the secure channel by Wednesday? Please confirm the reporting period, or let us know when the documents will be available.

Scenario 2 | Debt-service inputs need a period check

A fictional credit worksheet combines annual cash-flow figures with a quarterly debt-service figure. The correct matching-period inputs have not been obtained.

Role A: You are the credit analyst. Request matching-period inputs before relying on the DSCR calculation.

Role B: You maintain the financial file. Clarify the two periods and agree how to obtain the needed figures.

Possible opening: Could you provide debt service for the same period as the cash-flow figure before we use this ratio?

Success checks

- Identify the annual-versus-quarterly mismatch.
- Separate arithmetical calculation from a meaningful ratio.
- Request the correct inputs without inventing credit thresholds or an approval outcome.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests presenting the existing ratio because the arithmetic works.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Controls, Audit, Compliance, Fraud, and Ethics

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

SITUATION

A reconciliation has three unmatched entries. Their cause is unknown. The preparer is handing the work to a reviewer at the end of the day.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Internal control - Process designed to provide reasonable assurance around reporting, operations, or compliance.

Control deficiency - A control design or operating issue that may allow errors or misstatements.

Reconciliation - Process of comparing records and resolving differences.

Segregation of duties - Dividing responsibilities to reduce error or fraud risk.

3. Notice the language

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

Improve this sentence: Someone should follow up on this.

LESSON 07 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Transfer information and responsibility

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence checks that responsibility has been accepted?
 - A. I mentioned the check in my earlier email.
 - B. The check appears somewhere in the notes.
 - C. Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check.
2. Which response best checks a critical handoff detail?
 - A. I saw the message, so no clarification is needed.
 - B. So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct?
 - C. I assume all results are final, so we can finish.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Three unmatched entries at handoff

The lesson's preparer hands over a reconciliation with three unmatched entries whose cause is unknown.

01 • Reconciliation preparer: I'm handing over the reconciliation with three entries still unmatched. Their cause hasn't been established.

02 • Finance reviewer: What is complete, and where can I see the three outstanding items?

03 • Reconciliation preparer: The matching work completed so far is recorded, and the outstanding entries are identified in the working file.

04 • Finance reviewer: Should I treat them as evidence of fraud or a confirmed control deficiency?

05 • Reconciliation preparer: No. Unmatched entries require review; their existence alone doesn't establish either conclusion.

06 • Finance reviewer: I'll investigate the supporting records while preserving the preparer's work and review separation.

07 • Reconciliation preparer: Good. Please keep any proposed adjustments separate from entries that have actually been approved.

08 • Finance reviewer: Understood. No unexplained balance will be silently removed just to make the reconciliation match.

09 • Reconciliation preparer: Could you confirm your next action so the end-of-day handoff is clear?

10 • Finance reviewer: I'll review the three items and report findings and unresolved questions through the normal control process.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A review signature with missing evidence

Separate fictional control review: a payment file has a reviewer signature, but the referenced supporting document is absent.

01 • Control tester: The file has a review signature, but the referenced supporting document is missing from the material I received.

02 • Audit manager: Have you established that the review wasn't performed, or only that evidence is unavailable?

03 • Control tester: Only the evidence gap. I haven't confirmed what the reviewer actually examined.

04 • Audit manager: Then hand that limitation over without calling it a proven control failure.

05 • Control tester: I'll identify the payment reference and missing document in the restricted testing record.

06 • Audit manager: What follow-up are you asking the next reviewer to perform on this item?

07 • Control tester: Seek the support and assess what it shows about the review, without recreating evidence as though original.

08 • Audit manager: I'll take that request and retain the distinction between performance and documentation.

09 • Control tester: Please record any further evidence and whether the testing conclusion changes.

10 • Audit manager: Agreed. The current status is an unresolved evidence gap, not a completed adverse finding.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An access overlap needs assessment

Separate fictional controls exercise: an access report shows one person can prepare and approve payments; actual use of those permissions has not been checked.

01 • Internal control analyst: The access report shows one person with preparation and approval permissions. I'm handing it over for review.

02 • Controls manager: Does the report show they actually approved a payment they prepared?

03 • Internal control analyst: No. We have the permission overlap, not a confirmed transaction-level event.

04 • Controls manager: Then the segregation-of-duties concern needs assessment without assuming misuse or intent.

05 • Internal control analyst: I'll provide the role report and note that actual activity hasn't been examined.

06 • Controls manager: Are you asking me to approve a removal or to assess the exposure first?

07 • Internal control analyst: Assess it and identify the authorized response. I haven't established the full operational context.

08 • Controls manager: I'll review the permissions and relevant evidence through the controls process.

09 • Internal control analyst: Please confirm who owns any follow-up so the concern doesn't disappear after handoff.

10 • Controls manager: I'll own the assessment and distinguish recommendations from changes that are actually authorized and completed.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Controls, Audit, Compliance, Fraud, and Ethics

A reconciliation has three unmatched entries. Their cause is unknown. The preparer is handing the work to a reviewer at the end of the day.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Second round: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Model for scenario 1: Three entries remain unmatched. I've listed their references and the checks already completed. Please review the supporting records and record the resolution; the cause is still unconfirmed.

Scenario 2 | An exception report with an unchecked duplicate

A fictional payment exception report flags two records with the same invoice number. Their amounts and supplier identifiers have not been compared. No duplicate payment is confirmed.

Role A: You prepare controls reports. Hand over the flagged pair and state the unperformed checks.

Role B: You are the reviewer. Confirm the next comparison and avoid assuming fraud or duplicate payment.

Possible opening: Two records share an invoice number, but the supplier and amount checks are still pending.

Success checks

- Distinguish an exception flag from a confirmed duplicate.
- Name the missing comparisons.
- Confirm review ownership and preserve the absence of any recovery finding.

Add a complication: A manager wants the case title to say duplicate payment recovered, although no recovery occurred.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Valuation, M&A, Capital Allocation, and Executive Finance

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

A valuation model changes materially when the growth assumption moves from 2% to 4%. The presentation shows only the higher estimate.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

DCF - Discounted cash flow valuation based on projected cash flows and discount rate.

WACC - Weighted average cost of capital; a common discount-rate input.

Enterprise value - Value of the operating business, often before deducting net debt.

Sensitivity - Analysis showing how results change when an assumption changes.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Improve this sentence: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 08 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change definitely caused the delay.
 - B. The change may have contributed to the delay.
 - C. The change must have caused the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. In this pilot, the observed result was ...
 - B. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...
 - C. Across the service, the observed result was ...

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Showing both growth assumptions

The lesson's valuation changes materially between 2% and 4% growth assumptions, but the presentation shows only the higher estimate.

01 • Valuation analyst: The model changes materially when growth moves from two to four percent, but we show only the higher estimate.

02 • Finance director: Could the higher figure be presented as the company's established value?

03 • Valuation analyst: No. It depends on an assumption, and the sensitivity should be visible to the decision group.

04 • Finance director: Would including both estimates imply that every value between them is equally likely?

05 • Valuation analyst: Not automatically. The sensitivity illustrates model dependence; it doesn't assign probabilities to the assumptions.

06 • Finance director: We should explain that distinction alongside the DCF result in plain language.

07 • Valuation analyst: Yes. Discounted cash flow uses modeled future cash flows and a discount rate, both requiring support.

08 • Finance director: I'll ask for the growth rationale and keep the alternative case in the presentation.

09 • Valuation analyst: I'll also identify other assumptions held constant rather than imply growth is the only uncertainty.

10 • Finance director: Good. Our conclusion will match the evidence, not the most attractive model output.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Enterprise value is not the equity proceeds

Separate fictional transaction model: a slide labels enterprise value as shareholder proceeds; debt and cash adjustments have not been assessed.

01 • Transaction manager: The model gives enterprise value. Can I call that the amount shareholders would receive?

02 • Corporate finance analyst: Not on the supplied analysis. Enterprise value and equity proceeds are different measures.

03 • Transaction manager: What needs to be checked before we explain the difference to executives?

04 • Corporate finance analyst: The relevant debt, cash, and transaction adjustments need assessment; they aren't supplied here.

05 • Transaction manager: Then I shouldn't fill the bridge with assumed zero balances to simplify the slide.

06 • Corporate finance analyst: Correct. Missing adjustments must stay visible rather than become invented facts.

07 • Transaction manager: Could we retain enterprise value as a model output while marking proceeds unestablished?

08 • Corporate finance analyst: Yes. Also keep the model assumptions attached so the figure isn't presented as a guaranteed price.

09 • Transaction manager: I'll request the missing bridge inputs and correct the shareholder-proceeds label.

10 • Corporate finance analyst: Then the discussion can distinguish the modeled valuation from a transaction outcome not yet established.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A lower discount rate is not new operating evidence

Separate fictional valuation exercise: cash-flow forecasts stay unchanged while an analyst lowers the model's WACC; the assumption has not been approved.

01 • Strategy director: The valuation increased after your update. Did the business generate stronger forecast cash flows?

02 • Valuation analyst: No. The cash flows are unchanged; I tested a lower weighted average cost of capital.

03 • Strategy director: So the change reflects the WACC assumption rather than new operating evidence?

04 • Valuation analyst: Exactly. It's a sensitivity case, and the revised rate hasn't been approved.

05 • Strategy director: Can we say the company has become more valuable because this output is higher?

06 • Valuation analyst: That would confuse a model change with an established change in the business or market assessment.

07 • Strategy director: I'll ask for the rate rationale and compare the outputs with the assumptions stated.

08 • Valuation analyst: Good. We should hold the cash-flow basis constant when explaining this particular sensitivity.

09 • Strategy director: The presentation will identify the tested input and avoid calling the case an approved valuation.

10 • Valuation analyst: That makes the result transparent without treating a chosen discount rate as a discovered fact.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Valuation, M&A, Capital Allocation, and Executive Finance

A valuation model changes materially when the growth assumption moves from 2% to 4%. The presentation shows only the higher estimate.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: The valuation is sensitive to the growth assumption. I'll present both scenarios and explain the assumptions behind them. The higher figure is a modeled outcome, not an assured transaction value.

Scenario 2 | Savings enter the model before costs

A fictional acquisition model includes proposed annual savings but excludes integration costs because they have not been estimated. No net-benefit conclusion is approved.

Role A: You review the valuation. Explain the missing cost side and limit the claim.

Role B: You sponsor the acquisition analysis. Ask what estimate is needed before discussing net value.

Possible opening: The model includes proposed savings, but it cannot yet establish net benefit without integration costs.

Success checks

- Separate proposed savings from realized benefits.
- Identify unestimated integration costs.
- Agree a fuller assessment without assigning invented values or certainty.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to call the savings guaranteed value creation.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response to scenario 1, not a script to memorize. Assess your spoken version using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Finance Communication: Drivers, Assumptions, Materiality, Risk

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: C - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

B: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

C: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

Check 2: B - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

B: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

C: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

Model response: Revenue exceeded budget, but higher operating costs more than offset the increase. I'll show the main cost drivers so the review explains why profit moved differently from revenue.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Financial Statements, Close, and Accounting Judgments

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: B - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

B: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

C: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

Check 2: A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

B: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

C: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

Model response: Are we discussing the cash payment date or the accounting period for the expense? The payment was in January; the accounting treatment needs to follow our policy and the service details.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | FP&A, Budgeting, Forecasting, and Variance Analysis

Editing example: Three checks are complete; two remain open and are being reviewed.

The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Check 1: A - The team has completed the review.

A: 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.

B: 'Is completing' presents the work as in progress.

C: 'Plans to complete' describes an intention, not completion.

Check 2: C - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it.

A: A plan does not establish carrier confirmation.

B: A plan cannot prove a future arrival time.

C: This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

Model response: Spending is forecast to be \$20,000 above budget. The supplier fee explains \$15,000 of that variance. We are still reviewing the remaining \$5,000 and will update the bridge tomorrow.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Treasury, Cash, Liquidity, Working Capital, and FX

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: C - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

B: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

C: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

Check 2: B - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

B: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

C: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

Model response: The forecast assumes payment on Friday; that date is not confirmed. I'll show the balance both with and without the receipt so the team can see the liquidity exposure.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Markets, Investments, Performance, and Client Communication

Editing example: This option is better on cost, but slower to deliver.

'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Check 1: B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.

A: 'So' implies one fact causes the other.

B: 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.

C: 'Because' claims a causal connection that is not given.

Check 2: A - An increase of one percentage point.

A: Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

B: A one-percent relative increase on 6% would be 6.06%, not 7%.

C: The new rate is 7%; the difference between the rates is one percentage point.

Model response: The figures suggest a one-percentage-point difference before fees. We should label fee treatment and confirm the comparison basis before describing the performance to a client.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Banking, Credit, Lending, and Counterparty Risk

Editing example: Could you send the missing document and confirm when it will be available?

The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Check 1: A - Send it no later than Thursday.

A: 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.

B: "By Thursday" permits earlier delivery; it is not restricted to that day.

C: This interprets a deadline as a continuing activity, which would use "until".

Check 2: C - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

A: This checks importance rather than identifying the needed document version.

B: This checks receipt, not which version is required for the review.

C: The requested action and information are explicit.

Model response: Could you send the latest approved financial statements through the secure channel by Wednesday? Please confirm the reporting period, or let us know when the documents will be available.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Controls, Audit, Compliance, Fraud, and Ethics

Editing example: Please confirm which team has accepted the follow-up task.

The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Check 1: C - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check.

A: Mentioning a task does not show that anyone accepted it.

B: A written record alone does not identify who will act.

C: It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.

Check 2: B - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct?

A: Receiving a message is not the same as confirming its meaning.

B: This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

C: It changes pending information into a final result.

Model response: Three entries remain unmatched. I've listed their references and the checks already completed. Please review the supporting records and record the resolution; the cause is still unconfirmed.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Valuation, M&A, Capital Allocation, and Executive Finance

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: B - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

B: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

C: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

Check 2: A - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

B: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

C: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

Model response: The valuation is sensitive to the growth assumption. I'll present both scenarios and explain the assumptions behind them. The higher figure is a modeled outcome, not an assured transaction value.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Investor.gov: investing glossary

<https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/glossary>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Finance English

Professional audience: accounting, FP&A, treasury, banking, investments, audit, risk, corporate finance, and finance-adjacent teams

Scope: Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Lesson 01: Finance Communication: Drivers, Assumptions, Materiality, Risk

Original fictional case: Revenue is 5% above budget, while operating profit is 2% below budget. A manager wants a one-sentence explanation for a review meeting.

Language workshop: Make a complex point clear

Communication goal: Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

Language guidance: Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): In this context, ... means / The difference is that / How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Vocabulary: Revenue: Income from delivering goods or services, recognized under applicable accounting rules. / Operating income: Profit from operations before items such as interest and taxes, depending on presentation. / Variance: Difference between actual and comparison point such as budget, forecast, or prior period. / Sensitivity: Analysis showing how results change when an assumption changes.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Revenue exceeded budget, but higher operating costs more than offset the increase. I'll show the main cost drivers so the review explains why profit moved differently from revenue.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Grammar that changes the meaning

1. For a lesson, use its language workshop as the focus. For a dialogue, quote one actual sentence and select one useful grammar feature from it, such as question word order, tense, modality, conditionals or clause linking. Explain in no more than 90 words how this feature helps the speakers do their work. Keep the grammar target narrow.
2. Give two short contrasting sentences using this workplace context. Explain the difference in time, certainty, condition or politeness. Label invented examples and preserve the distinction between possible, planned and confirmed events. Describe context-dependent choices as choices, not universal rules.
3. Give me one editing or sentence-building task using a known case fact. Do not copy the supplied editing example or reveal its answer. Ask me to explain my intended meaning. Stop and wait.
4. After I answer, quote my wording, identify at most two issues, and give a brief explanation and one hint. Ask me to revise before offering a full corrected version. Then accept any accurate, natural alternative that serves the purpose.
5. Continue with two new tasks, one at a time: first guided, then an original response without a sentence frame. End with a two-sentence workplace message using the target feature and a compact self-check. Do not replace this sequence with a worksheet and answer key.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Get feedback on a draft

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Finance English

Professional audience: accounting, FP&A, treasury, banking, investments, audit, risk, corporate finance, and finance-adjacent teams

Scope: Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Lesson 01: Finance Communication: Drivers, Assumptions, Materiality, Risk

Original fictional case: Revenue is 5% above budget, while operating profit is 2% below budget. A manager wants a one-sentence explanation for a review meeting.

Language workshop: Make a complex point clear

Communication goal: Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

Language guidance: Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): In this context, ... means ... / The difference is that ... / How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Vocabulary: Revenue: Income from delivering goods or services, recognized under applicable accounting rules. / Operating income: Profit from operations before items such as interest and taxes, depending on presentation. / Variance: Difference between actual and comparison point such as budget, forecast, or prior period. / Sensitivity: Analysis showing how results change when an assumption changes.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Revenue exceeded budget, but higher operating costs more than offset the increase. I'll show the main cost drivers so the review explains why profit moved differently from revenue.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Coach my workplace writing

1. Ask me to paste my own fictional or anonymized draft and identify its reader and purpose. If the reference gives a writing task, mention that task as the default. If it is a dialogue, suggest a brief follow-up message that records its outcome and open questions. Stop and wait. Do not write the message for me first.
2. Once I supply the draft, check it against the reference. If an ambiguity changes the meaning, ask one focused question before rewriting. Do not assume that the draft is correct evidence for a new deadline, approval, diagnosis, cost or commitment.
3. Give feedback in three parts: one effective phrase with a reason; up to three priority improvements, quoting my words; and one short revision task for me. Prioritize incorrect facts or unclear action before minor grammar. For each language correction, explain why it matters to this reader. Label optional stylistic alternatives separately and preserve my level of certainty and intended politeness.
4. Stop and wait for my revision. Then compare the two attempts, identify an improvement and offer one edited version that preserves my voice and purpose. Keep the requested length; if none is specified, use 70-110 words. Explain any meaningful change rather than silently making the message stronger or more certain.
5. Close with one phrase worth reusing and a short transfer task for a different fictional reader. Wait for my attempt before providing another model.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level